The unilateral option is not the preferred mode of action but rather the fallback option, a path to be taken when there is no one to talk to, and yet you want to make progress on solving the conflict. The examples of the one-sided options that I myself supported did not yield heartwarming results. I am referring, of course, to the unilateral withdrawal from Lebanon and the evacuation from the Gaza Strip. These Israeli concessions, which did not demand anything in return, expanded the scope of conflict rather than reduced it. Moreover, in both cases Israel did not stand behind its declarations that it would respond harshly to any provocation after the unilateral moves, and for that it paid a price in its deterrent capability. The only case that has proven to be a success over the test of time has been the security fence, which was intended to block the infiltration of suicide bombers from the territories into Israel. The reason that as of 2016 the fence has not yet been completed was the resistance from the extreme Right.

We are all lovers of life and most of us are also peace-loving, and we often ask the question “Shall the sword devour forever?” I am among those who ask this question. But in 2010 I assessed that the conditions for ending the conflict were not ripe. I hoped I was wrong. But, I concluded, if I was not, all we could do was adopt a strategy of continuing to manage the conflict in an attempt to keep it on as low a burner as possible, identify issues, even small ones, on which we could agree, and proceed to take controlled unilateral steps to prevent stagnation. And until we could finally achieve peace, we had to maintain our deterrent capability, our ability to achieve decisive victories, our economic and technological superiority, our alliance with the United States, and our national strength.

To sum up, in 2010 it seemed to me that despite our will and desire to achieve peace, to my great regret, a cold analysis of the current global, regional, and local conditions led to the conclusion that the best that could be achieved is a delicate coexistence, accompanied by efforts to create an environment of mutual interests between the parties, which at some point down the road would hopefully develop into a peace agreement.

Over half a decade passed, and the optimistic hopes I held in 2010 had not been realized. In mid-2016 I found myself involved in another attempt at a unilateral move, initiated by the movement “Commanders for Israel’s Security.” The movement’s plan was based on a realistic approach that recognized that current conditions were not yet ripe for a discussion on the core issues of a final status agreement. The plan adopted an approach that